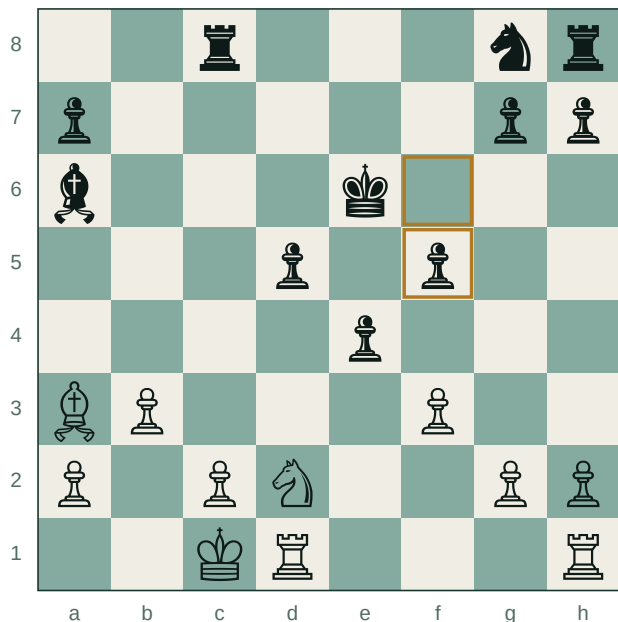


Clearance tactics: White, move 19

Clearance tactics

White to move



Previous move: 18...f5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

19. fxe4 fxe4 20. Nxe4 dxe4 21. Rd6+ Kf7 22. Rxa6

19.fxe4 The pawn captures the pawn on e4. Recorded reply: **19...fxe4**.

20.Nxe4 The knight captures the pawn on e4. Recorded reply: **20...dxe4**.

21.Rd6+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. From d6 it attacks king on e6 and bishop on a6. Recorded reply: **21...Kf7**.

22.Rxa6 The rook captures the bishop on a6.

At the end, nominal material is White 18 / Black 17 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1:** the balance goes from +0 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Opening a line helps only if your next move is timely. The defender may close the line or create a stronger threat.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A clearance move vacates a square or opens a line for another piece. The clearing piece may sacrifice itself to gain the time needed for the follow-up.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the rook, bishop, queen, or knight that needs access, then locate the friendly piece blocking its route or destination.

The defending king is on e6. Geometrically undefended: rook on h8 and bishop on a6. Check for tactical protection.